

The Wannsee Conference was far from the start of Nazi brutality against Jews. Adolf Hitler had come to power in 1933, spreading his belief that Germans were the Aryan master race, superior to all others, and that their blood should not be contaminated. He identified Jews as a race of people, not just a religious group. German Jews were banned from marrying non-Jewish Germans and subjected to increasing discrimination and segregation. From the time of the German takeover of Austria in 1938, Nazi brutality against Jews worsened. Jews wanting to flee German rule found other countries unwilling to accept them.

Gathering momentum

After Germany's invasion of Poland in 1939, the Nazi campaign against the Jews reached a terrifying new level. Herded into ghettos, Polish Jews began to die in large numbers of starvation and ill-treatment.

When Germany invaded Russia in 1941, paramilitary death squads carried out mass killings of Jews in the conquered areas. To start with, victims were shot, up to 30,000 at a time, but the SS then began gassing Jews in the backs of vans. Poison gas was found to be a more efficient way to commit mass murder.

Until 1941, the Nazi leadership had envisaged solving the "Jewish problem" by deporting Jews to a distant location. By the time of the Wannsee Conference, however, they were committed to systematically killing Europe's Jewish population. Six dedicated

death camps were built in Poland. Adolf Eichmann of the Nazi paramilitary corps, the SS, arranged the transportation of Jews to the camps from right across Europe, including France, Greece, Hungary, and Italy. The Jews from the Polish ghettos were also taken there to be exterminated. Prisoners arrived at these huge killing factories by train and were gassed in shower rooms, their corpses burned in large crematoria. At the Belzec camp, about half a million Jews were killed, and only seven prisoners are known to have survived. The death camp at Auschwitz, however, also had a labor camp attached, where those who were not killed on arrival were made to work. The Germans needed slave labor to support their war effort, and this offered Jews their best chance of survival. Along with other prisoners—including socialists, homosexuals, Roma, and prisoners of war—many Jews were sent to concentration camps. Their heads were shaved, and they were given a uniform to strip them of their identity. When the Allies liberated the camps in 1945, they found a vision of hell. The survivors were skeletal and traumatized.

State-sanctioned genocide

The Wannsee Protocol, the minutes of the conference, represents the unimaginable. For the first time, a modern state had committed itself to the murder of an entire people. As many as 6 million Jews lost their lives, and an estimated 5.5 million others—Slavs, homosexuals, communists—were also killed. ■

The Nuremberg Trials

After the end of World War II, the Allies sought to bring the Nazis to justice. An international tribunal was held at Nuremberg, Germany, beginning in 1945. Newsreels captured from the Nazis revealed the gas chambers, the massacre of civilians, and the ill-treatment of

prisoners. The trials were televised, showing to the world—and, in particular the German people—evidence of the horrors that had taken place in the concentration camps.

Adolf Hitler; Heinrich Himmler, head of the SS; and Joseph Goebbels, head of propaganda, had committed suicide, leaving 24 defendants facing four counts: crimes against peace, planning and waging

wars of aggression, war crimes, and crimes against humanity. Most said they were "only obeying orders." Albert Speer, head of war production, was jailed for 20 years, while 12 of the other defendants were sentenced to death; the trials led to the setting up of a permanent international criminal court in The Hague, in the Netherlands.